

Wednesday, 7 December 2022

## **Meeting Communiqué**

Commonwealth, state, and territory agriculture Ministers met virtually on Wednesday

7 December 2022 for the third and final Agriculture Ministers' Meeting (AMM) of the year.

AMM was chaired by the Australian Minister for Agriculture, Fisheries and Forestry, Senator the Hon Murray Watt.

### **Flood emergency**

Ministers acknowledged the meeting was taking place as devastating floods continued to affect rural communities across Australia. Ministers' thoughts are with those doing it tough and showing great resilience during this time, with those Ministers from flood affected jurisdictions actively focused on supporting communities to respond and recover. The floods follow years of drought, the Black Summer bushfires and disruptions caused by COVID.

Ministers discussed the impact of the floods and the ongoing emergency response. Farmers across multiple jurisdictions are facing considerable damage and disruption from flooding. The support provided by the Government to date was noted and Ministers pledged continued support including road repair.

### **Federal Budget**

Ministers noted initiatives for agriculture announced in the Federal Budget. These include biosecurity measures to protect Australia from threats such as foot and mouth disease and lumpy skin disease and continued funding to the Natural Heritage Trust to support sustainable farming practices.

### **Update on the Agriculture Workforce Working Group**

Ministers acknowledged workforce shortages are still a key issue facing agriculture. Minister Watt said the tripartite Agriculture Workforce Working Group has met twice to keep driving outcomes on this priority for both immediate and longer-term needs. Minister Watt was pleased to share that worker numbers under the PALM scheme are now the highest they have ever been, that the Commonwealth is making good progress clearing the huge backlog of visa applications that existed earlier this year, and the Commonwealth has now committed 8,950 fee-free TAFE places for agricultural training under Skills Agreements with South Australia, New South Wales, Tasmania and Western Australia.

As agriculture workforce matters are a key priority for the AMM, it agreed this will be a standing agenda item for future meetings.

## Ongoing role for the AMM

Ministers welcomed National Cabinet's recent decision to make the AMM an ongoing, collaborative ministerial forum, focused on national priorities.

AMM's agreed priorities will focus on biosecurity, climate change and workforce matters. It will also consider matters such as farm animal welfare matters of national significance, reform of agricultural and veterinary chemicals regulation and oversight of the National Drought Agreement.

Under new streamlined arrangements for Australia's federal relations, AMM will report to National Cabinet annually on its achievements for the year and provide a forward work plan.

## Climate change

Ministers discussed the significant climate challenges facing agriculture and the opportunities for the industry in transitioning to a net zero economy. The AMM acknowledged the productive work underway by industry on climate and agriculture policies and programs.

Ministers agreed in-principle to bring together this significant work into a national statement on climate and agriculture. The national statement will demonstrate a broad but unified vision and priorities for the sector articulating that the government is committed to supporting it to sustainably manage the impacts of climate change while growing and increasing value of the nation's agriculture.

## Farm debt mediation

Ministers welcomed the release of the national better practice guide for farm debt mediation (FDM). The guide outlines high-level principles for farmers and their lenders to use when working to resolve debt issues.

The guide was prepared in consultation with the states and territories and stakeholders including the National Farmers' Federation and Australian Banking Association. It complements existing state FDM schemes and the Banking Code of Practice and aligns with recommendations of the Banking Royal Commission.

The better practice guide is available at [agriculture.gov.au/FDM](https://agriculture.gov.au/FDM)

## National Drought Agreement

Ministers endorsed the annual report of the second National Drought Agreement (NDA). There has been considerable progress developing nationally consistent drought policy and programs to drive long-term preparedness, sustainability, resilience and risk management for farming communities and businesses in Australia.

Ministers endorsed the NDA review report required before the current agreement expires on 30 June 2024 and agreed to accelerate recommendations to establish mechanisms to improve communication

between jurisdictions and with stakeholders. The review was undertaken with all states and territories and will guide negotiations on the third NDA which will start in 2023.

You can find these documents at [agriculture.gov.au/drought](https://agriculture.gov.au/drought)

Ministers noted the growing community concern around animal welfare issues and industry's efforts to meet community expectations, in particular the horse industry. Ministers also noted the Australian government's commitment of \$5 million over 4 years to renew the Australian Animal Welfare Strategy.

Ministers tasked their [Agriculture Senior Officials' Committee's](#) (AGSOC) Animal Welfare Task Group – the cross-jurisdictional group with responsibility for national farm animal welfare policy and standards setting – with developing options to improve the process for developing national standards and guidelines for animal welfare. AGSOC will present the task group's options to AMM early next year.

Recognising the desire for new or updated animal welfare standards for a range of industries – for example, horses – Ministers agreed that their next meeting will work towards prioritising particular standards.

Minister Watt updated his counterparts on the new Inspector-General for Animal Welfare. The Inspector-General will improve animal welfare assurance and increase accountability and transparency for exported livestock.

Ministers were provided with an update from the National Biosecurity Strategy Implementation Committee's first meeting on 28 October 2022.

Following commissioning of Ministers at their 9 September meeting, the implementation committee is developing the National Biosecurity Strategy Implementation Plan. Dedicated work on the Plan over the coming months will guide longer-term coordinated biosecurity efforts.

Ministers noted 2022 has been a challenging year for Australia's biosecurity system with Varroa mite in New South Wales, and the adjustment of settings in response to foot and mouth and lumpy skin disease outbreaks in Indonesia.

Ministers noted the system continues to perform well, while evolving as required. This includes developing new response capabilities, both within individual jurisdictions and nationally.

Ministers also noted the extensive work done on preparedness and the importance of work undertaken by industry groups and other stakeholders to support this heightened activity.

## **Livestock traceability**

Ministers considered the final report of the National Horse Traceability Working Group (NHTWG) that is advising the AMM and the Australasian Racing Ministers' Conference on traceability for horses, donkeys, and mules.

There are serious diseases affecting horses that are either not present in Australia or occur sporadically. Notable examples include exotic diseases such as equine influenza and African horse sickness, as well as endemic diseases such as Hendra virus.

Ministers accepted the recommendation for strengthened property identification and national movement reporting requirements to trace infected and potentially exposed horses.

A National Horse Traceability Implementation Taskforce, led by industry representatives, will oversee the implementation and operation of the traceability system on behalf of the jurisdictions.

The NHTWG final report is available at [Agriculture Victoria](#)

Ministers reiterated their intention to implement harmonised tagging requirements for all managed farmed sheep and goats using individual electronic identification, working towards 1 January 2025 implementation. Key milestones being worked towards include tagging all managed farmed sheep and goats born on or after 1 January 2025, tagging all managed farmed sheep and goats leaving their property of birth or last property of residence, and having sufficient infrastructure in place to allow the scanning of tagged animals as they move through the supply chain. Implementation in jurisdictions will be guided by the needs of industry and producers.

Ministers further noted livestock traceability is a shared responsibility between all governments and industry, and the Commonwealth has committed \$20.1 million for co-investment with states and territories to support industry eID transition and on-farm and off-farm traceability. Bilateral agreements for co-investment with states and territories will be developed to support equitable distribution of Commonwealth funding.

## **Fruit fly**

Ministers agreed that maintaining Sterile Insect Technology capacity in Australia is in the national interest and that addressing trade issues should have high priority.

Further work will be progressed urgently with a view to resolve trade issues early in 2023. Officials will further prioritise the development of ongoing national standards.

## **Next meeting**

The AMM's meeting schedule for 2023 is being finalised with a face-to-face meeting planned.

Ministerial attendees:

- Australian Government (Chair): Senator the Hon Murray Watt, Minister for Agriculture, Fisheries and Forestry
- New South Wales: the Hon Dugald Saunders MP, Minister for Agriculture
- Victoria: Mr Matt Lowe, Chief Executive Agriculture Victoria – proxy for the Hon Gayle Tierney MLC, Minister for Agriculture
- Queensland: the Hon Mark Furner MP, Minister for Agriculture and Fisheries

- Western Australia: the Hon Alannah MacTiernan MLC, Minister for Agriculture and Food
- South Australia: the Hon Clare Scriven MLC, Minister for Primary Industries and Regions
- Tasmania: the Hon Jo Palmer MLC, Minister for Primary Industries and Water
- Australian Capital Territory: Ms Rebecca Vassarotti MLA, Minister for the Environment
- Northern Territory: the Hon Paul Kirby MLA, Minister for Agribusiness and Fisheries

Source: <https://www.agriculture.gov.au/about/news/stay-informed/communiques/ag-ministers-forum-dec-2022>